23900320

MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (Honours)/ MGU-BBA (Honours)/ MGU-BCA (Honours)

REGULAR EXAMINATION OCTOBER 2026

FIFTH SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG5DSCJMC300 - DOCUMENTARY PRODUCTION

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 2 Hours **Maximum Marks: 70**

ANSWER KEY

Part A

Answer all questions.

Each question carries 1 mark.

1. A. John Grierson.
2. D. The final broadcast rating of the film.
3. A. A subject framed roughly from the waist up.
4. B. During pre-production, alongside the shooting schedule.
5. A. Syncing audio and video.
6. B. Lavalier microphone.
7. A. Camera, tripod and microphone.
8. A. Establish consistent visual mood and style across the film.
9. B. Key facts, characters and the story's central thread.
10. A. Editing, sound design and colour grading expenses.

(10 × 1 = 10)

Part B

Answer any ten questions.

Each question carries 3 marks.

11. The Films Division was established in 1948 under the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting. It produced documentaries, newsreels and short films for public exhibition. It documented national events, development programmes, history, culture and social issues; informed and educated audiences; supported documentary production expertise; and created an audiovisual record of post-Independence India. It helped institutionalise documentary filmmaking and made it an important tool of public communication.
12. Research establishes factual accuracy, identifies the central issue and story thread, locates people and places, reveals ethical or safety concerns, and informs the budget and schedule. Secondary research includes books, reports, archives, articles and existing films. Primary research includes preliminary

interviews, site visits, observation and discussions with experts or community members. Research makes the film focused, credible and feasible.

13. Natural light changes with time, weather and sun direction, affecting exposure and continuity. The crew should assess intensity, direction and colour and plan accordingly. Artificial light gives control over brightness, direction and contrast, fills shadows and can separate a subject from the background. Check white balance, mixed colour temperatures, harsh shadows and safety. Balancing both sources supports clear, natural-looking and consistent footage.

14. A promotional strategy helps a documentary reach its intended audience, communicate relevance and build interest before release. It can support festivals, screenings, partnerships and publicity. Methods include (1) a social-media campaign using trailers, posters, short clips, behind-the-scenes content and hashtags; and (2) media/community outreach through press releases, interviews, previews and partnerships with NGOs, colleges or community groups. Promotion should start in pre-production and continue through release.

15. A release or consent form records a participant's informed agreement to be filmed or recorded and to have the contribution edited, exhibited or distributed within the agreed scope. It may identify the participant, permitted use of image and voice, and any conditions. It promotes transparency and helps manage legal and ethical risks. Consent should be voluntary and understandable; a signed form does not remove the filmmaker's duty to protect privacy and avoid misleading representation.

16. A fiction screenplay usually plans scenes, dialogue, characters and actions in a controlled narrative. A documentary pre-production script may be a proposal, treatment, outline or shooting script identifying the subject, intended structure, likely sequences, interview areas, locations and visual approach. Real events cannot be fully predicted, so documentary plans remain flexible and change as evidence or events emerge. Fiction generally scripts a planned story; documentary scripting prepares for actuality.

17. Check wardrobe, appearance and accessories; positions of props and background objects; lighting direction, intensity, colour temperature, white balance and exposure; camera lens, focal length, framing, angle and movement; microphone placement, sound levels and room tone; action, eyelines and screen direction. Record shot details, label files and maintain logs so the editor can match footage and maintain continuity.

18. Consider target audience and viewing habits; purpose such as education, awareness, advocacy, festivals or commercial release; subject and genre; reach and accessibility, including subtitles and captions; costs, licensing, exclusivity and rights; technical delivery requirements; and promotional support or audience engagement. Choose the platform that reaches the intended audience and meets the film's goals, budget and rights conditions.

19. Sound conveys dialogue, location, mood and realism. Clear speech supports understanding; ambient sound establishes place; music may shape emotion and silence can create emphasis. Sound editing balances levels, reduces distracting noise and maintains continuity. Poor sound can undermine excellent visuals. Sound choices should support the evidence and must not manipulate or misrepresent events.

20. Footage review identifies usable shots and strong interview statements; checks focus, exposure, framing and sound; reveals gaps or continuity problems requiring additional shooting; allows clips to be logged, labelled and organised; helps verify claims and identify facts needing confirmation; and prevents important moments being missed. It turns raw recordings into organised material and improves the efficiency, accuracy and ethics of editing.

21. Levels that are too low create weak recordings and amplify noise; levels that are too high clip and distort speech. Test with the actual speaker, monitor meters and headphones, leave headroom for loud sounds, check cables and batteries, and listen for wind, clothing rustle, handling noise, echo and background sound. Record a short test and confirm clarity and synchronisation. These checks protect intelligibility and reduce reshoots.

22. The DoP translates the director's vision into visual choices: framing, shot sizes, angles, movement and visual style. The DoP selects camera/lens equipment, manages lighting and exposure, checks focus, white balance, frame rate and recording format, coordinates with camera and sound crew, maintains continuity and shot notes, and ensures equipment is safe and ready. Documentary work also requires adaptability and ethical sensitivity so filming respects participants and does not mislead viewers.

(10 × 3 = 30)

Part C

Answer any two questions.

Each question carries 15 marks.

23. Introduction: Interviews and observational footage are complementary methods. Interviews provide testimony, explanation, memory, expert context and viewpoints; observational footage shows actions, places, interactions and everyday details. Interviews: They explain causes, motives and consequences, introduce context and present different perspectives. Select concise sound bites that advance the story. Interview accounts are subjective, so important claims may need verification. Observational footage: It establishes place, shows processes and adds visual evidence, atmosphere and natural sound. However, images also require context; selective framing can mislead. Combining the methods: Begin with an establishing shot, introduce the issue through an interview, use observational scenes or cutaways to show the relevant context, then return to an interview that deepens or challenges the point. Natural sound can bridge edits and maintain continuity. Ethics: Represent contrasting accounts fairly. Do not use unrelated images to imply a false connection or edit words misleadingly. Verify factual claims where possible and respect participants' privacy and dignity. Conclusion: Interviews provide voice and interpretation, while observation provides action and context. Carefully combined, they produce an informative, engaging and credible sequence.

24. Title: *Pause Before You Post* | Duration: 5–7 minutes | Audience: School and college students. Purpose and message: Encourage viewers to verify information, protect privacy, treat others respectfully and use social media thoughtfully. Research and planning: Research misinformation, cyberbullying, privacy settings, digital footprints and healthy screen habits using reliable sources. Interview students and an expert such as a media-literacy educator or cybersecurity professional. Obtain consent and protect vulnerable participants. Suggested sequence: • Opening (0:00–0:40): Notifications and a person about to forward a sensational post. Voice-over: "One tap can inform, mislead or hurt. What do we check before sharing?" • Problem (0:40–1:50): Short staged examples of a rumour, a hurtful comment and oversharing personal details. Identify misinformation, cyberbullying and privacy risks. • Voices (1:50–3:20): Student interviews and expert advice: how to verify a claim, respond to cyberbullying and protect personal information. • Practical response (3:20–5:30): Pause before forwarding; check source and date; read beyond headlines; ask permission before posting others' images; use privacy settings; block/report abuse; seek trusted help; balance screen time. • Conclusion: A student checks a source before sharing. Voice-over: "Be connected. Be kind. Be responsible." Visual and sound plan: Use close-ups, screen inserts, medium shots, observational footage and readable graphics. Hide real usernames and private messages. Use clear dialogue, restrained music and natural sound. Ethics and distribution: Label dramatized scenes, verify claims, protect minors and avoid fear-based exaggeration. Edit for clarity, add captions, check audio, and share through college screenings, educational institutions and social platforms. Conclusion: A flexible script combines evidence, real voices and practical actions, leaving viewers with achievable habits.

25. Introduction: Systematic setup improves image and sound quality, reduces technical failure and prepares the crew for unpredictable events. Camera: Check batteries, recording media and storage. Select suitable resolution, codec and frame rate according to delivery requirements. Set shutter speed

appropriately and check for flicker. Set white balance and exposure; check focus, lens, framing, stabilisation and tripod security. Record and play back a test clip. Keep spare batteries and media. Microphone and audio: Select a lavalier for interviews, boom/shotgun for directional dialogue, or a separate recorder as needed. Place the microphone close enough for clear speech but out of frame and away from clothing friction. Check cables, batteries, wireless signal and recorder settings. Monitor with headphones, set levels with headroom, and listen for wind, traffic, echo, hum and handling noise. Record room tone. When audio and video use separate devices, plan synchronisation using timecode, a clapper or a clear sync event. Lighting: Assess natural light direction and changes throughout the day. Use available light when appropriate; add key, fill or backlight only as required. Manage mixed colour temperatures, shadows and exposure. Secure stands and cables and follow electrical safety. Integrated checks: Test camera, sound and light together at the location, review a sample, label media, confirm permissions and keep backup equipment available. Conclusion: Professional setup depends on coordinated technical checks, not merely owning equipment. Testing before filming prevents avoidable failures and supports consistent footage.

26. Introduction: The most appropriate choice is the reflexive mode, associated with documentary theorist Bill Nichols. It draws attention to the process of making a documentary and asks viewers to question how images, interviews, narration and editing construct a representation of reality. Characteristics: 1. Makes filmmaking visible: It may reveal the camera, filmmaker, interview process or production decisions. 2. It questions objectivity: It reminds viewers that a documentary is shaped by selection, framing, access and editing rather than being a transparent copy of reality. 3. Examines representation: It can expose how questions, camera placement, narration or editing influence what appears to be true. 4. Encourages critical viewing: Viewers ask who tells the story, whose voices are missing and what evidence supports the claims. 5. Uses self-reflexive techniques: Production discussions, visible interventions, contradictory material or explanations of editorial choices may reveal the limits of filmmaking. Comparison: Observational mode tends to minimise visible filmmaker intervention; participatory mode foregrounds interaction between filmmaker and subject; performative mode emphasises subjective, embodied experience. These modes can overlap, but reflexive mode most directly questions documentary representation itself. Example: A film about a community issue could show how interview questions were framed, include a participant challenging the filmmaker's interpretation, or explain why some footage was selected or excluded. Conclusion: Reflexive mode is the strongest fit because it exposes how documentary meaning is constructed and encourages audiences to evaluate representation critically.

(2 × 15 = 30)

******